

# Comprehensive Business Ethics and Responsible Leadership

MS 491 VIII

SLOTS L1, L2

CREDIT 4

# Key Learnings from this Course

- Understand the core principles of business ethics and apply them to organizational decision-making
- Identify the roles and responsibilities of managers in fostering ethical behavior and implementing socially responsible and environmentally sustainable practices.
- Analyze the impact of public, governmental, and investor pressure on corporate sustainability strategies
- Evaluate corporate social responsibility (CSR) initiatives and their alignment with ethical and environmental goals
- Critically assess sustainability reports and understand their significance for transparency, stakeholder trust, and risk management
- Develop strategies to integrate ethical, social, and environmental considerations into business operations and long-term planning
- Apply case study insights to real-world scenarios involving ethical dilemmas and sustainability challenges in business

# Instructor

Dr. Ramachandran Veetikazhi is a joint doctorate holder from IIT Madras and the University of Duisburg-Essen, Germany, and headed the Learning & Development Division in one of India's biggest commercial enterprises. He is the winner of the Institute Research Award for exceptional research from IIT Madras and *Magna cum Laude* (distinction in research) from the University of Duisburg-Essen. Dr. Veetikazhi has over 35 years of executive experience and has won many awards from his organization. Dr. Veetikazhi has published papers in high-impact journals such as the *Business & Society*, *International Journal of Human Resource Management* and *Group & Organization Management*. He is a visiting faculty at IITGn for Business Ethics and Responsible Leadership. He is also a guest faculty at IIM Tiruchirappalli and IIT Hyderabad.

# Why This Course Is Important For You!

*This course in Comprehensive Business Ethics and Responsible Leadership is essential for students' careers because ethical judgment and responsibility are now core expectations across all professions, not only management roles. Engineers increasingly make decisions that affect public safety, environmental sustainability, and data privacy, while humanities graduates often shape organizational culture, communication, policy, and social impact. The course develops the ability to recognize ethical dilemmas, evaluate competing stakeholder interests, and make principled decisions under pressure. It also builds leadership capabilities such as integrity, accountability, and moral courage, which are critical for career advancement and trustworthiness. By understanding sustainability, ESG, and responsible governance, students become better prepared for organizations facing regulatory scrutiny and investor and public expectations. Ultimately, the course equips graduates from all disciplines to act as responsible professionals who can contribute to long-term organizational and societal well-being.*

# Evaluation and Reference Books

The evaluation shall be based on class participation, two assignments and an examination. Assignments and class participation =60; quizzes and examinations = 40.

- **Assignment 1:** Reflections, session-wise, approx. 300 words per session. 30 marks
- **Assignment 2:** Group presentations. 10-minute presentation, 5-minute Q&A. Maximum 10 slides (Brief of the case, ethical issues involved). Marks 20.
- **Class participation** – attendance, individual storytelling based on ethics. 10 marks
- **Textbooks**
  1. Managing business ethics: Straight Talk about how to do it right, 8th ed. by Trevino, Linda K. and Nelson, Katherine A. (available in IITGn library).
  2. Business ethics: ethical decision making and cases, 12th ed. by Ferrell, O. C., Fraedrich, John and Ferrell, Linda (available in IITGn library).
  3. Do good: Embracing brand citizenship to fuel both purpose and profit. (2018) Thompson.A.E., Amacom, New York. (available in IITGn library).
  4. Ethics and the conduct of business, 8th ed. by Boatright, J.R., Jeffery, D.S., and Patra, B.P.

# Class-wise Agenda

| Session | Core Ideas                                        | Details                                                                                                                            |
|---------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1       | Introduction to Business Ethics                   | Meaning, scope, and relevance of ethics in business, Ethics vs. law vs. morality, Why ethics matters in contemporary organizations |
| 2       | Ethical Theories and Frameworks                   | Utilitarianism, deontology, virtue ethics, Justice and rights-based approaches                                                     |
| 3       | Individual Differences in Ethical Decision making | Heinz Dilemma, Cognitive Moral Development, Locus of Control, Machiavellianism                                                     |
| 4       | Unconscious Biases and Ethical Blindness          | Biases in decision making, Slippery slope, Ethical numbing, Moral muteness                                                         |
| 5       | Culture, Ethics, and Organizations                | Ethical culture and ethical climate, Codes of ethics and conduct, Ethics training and leadership role modeling                     |
| 6       | Corporate Governance and Ethical Accountability   | Board responsibilities and executive ethics, Agency problem and stakeholder oversight, Scandals and governance failures            |
| 7       | Leadership and Ethics -1                          | Ethical leadership and responsible leadership, Power, influence, and moral responsibility                                          |
| 8       | Leadership and Ethics -2                          | Leadership character and integrity, Leadership Styles                                                                              |
| 9       | Stakeholder Theory and Ethical Management         | Identifying competing stakeholder claims, Stakeholder engagement strategies, balancing and prioritizing stakeholders,              |
| 10      | Corporate Social Responsibility                   | Evolution and dimensions of CSR, Instrumental vs. normative perspectives, CSR in emerging and developed economies                  |
| 11      | Responsible Leadership in Practice                | Values-based leadership, Role of managers in social responsibility, Case studies of responsible and irresponsible leadership       |
| 12      | Business Ethics and Human Rights                  | Labor standards and workplace dignity, Diversity, equity, and inclusion, Ethical challenges in global supply chains                |

# Class-wise Agenda

| Session | Core Ideas                                         | Details                                                                                                                                         |
|---------|----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 13      | Ethics of Marketing, Finance, and Operations       | Ethical issues in marketing and advertising, Financial ethics and accountability, Operations, sourcing, and supplier responsibility             |
| 14      | Sustainable Development and the Triple Bottom Line | Environmental ethics and sustainability, Business impact on ecosystems, Climate change and corporate responsibility                             |
| 15      | Environment Management and Strategy                | Economic, social, and environmental performance, Trade-offs and tensions in sustainability, Long-term value creation                            |
| 16      | Sustainability Reporting and Disclosure            | Purpose and evolution of sustainability reporting, GRI, Integrated Reporting, and ESG frameworks, Public and investor pressure for transparency |
| 17      | Ethics in the Digital Economy                      | Data privacy and surveillance, Artificial intelligence and algorithmic bias, Technology, power, and accountability                              |
| 18      | ESG, Responsible Investment, Risk                  | Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) metrics, Investor expectations and ethical finance, Reputation, risk, and resilience                |
| 19      | Globalization and Business Ethics                  | Ethical challenges in multinational corporations, Cultural relativism vs. ethical universalism, Corruption and bribery                          |
| 20      | Whistleblowing and Ethical Courage                 | Whistleblower protection and retaliation, Organizational silence and speaking up, Moral courage in leadership                                   |
| 21      | Corporate Misconduct and Moral Disengagement       | Normalization of unethical behavior, Moral disengagement mechanisms, Preventing ethical drift                                                   |
| 22      | Ethics in Indian Philosophical Thoughts            | Evolution of Dharma concept, Ashoka and Edicts, Examples from Indian Texts                                                                      |
| 23      | Integration                                        |                                                                                                                                                 |
| 24      | Review and Discussion                              |                                                                                                                                                 |